The Button

By Robert Newman

The scene is a solitary confinement cell in a large American prison. It is a stone-walled room about six feet square and in it, a hard cot, no other object of any kind. The room is in absolute darkness. On the cot sits a prisoner, Joe Ransom, about forty years of age. He is in solitary after a prison riot in which another convict has been murdered. His head in his hands, he sits and rocks from side to side on the cot; the springs creak with every move. Suddenly he stops swaying, lifts his head and listens. Far away an iron door opens.

JOE: Warden! Warden! I knew you'd come. Warden, listen -- listen to me. Listen, Warden, you gotta take me out of here. You gotta, see? I'm goin' nuts. I can't stand it, Warden, I'm goin' nuts!

Look, look, Warden, I'll tell you what I'll do, see. I'll confess. Get me a pencil and paper and for a little light and I'll write out a confession. Then you can take me out and hang me. I'll confess see –Warden! *(shouts)* Warden, are you listenin'? I tell you I killed him. I killed him. I KILLED HIM!

INTRODUCTION

In the choking blackness of solitary confinement, Joe Ransom teeters on the brink of madness. A single match, a drifting spider, a worthless white button become his last defenses against the terror. He devises a simple game to protect his sanity. Will the game work or will the button prove to be his downfall?

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JOE: All right. All right. I'll be calm, see -- Calm an' quite, so's you'll know I mean what I'm sayin'. Listen: I, Joe Ransom killed my cellmate, Mike Malari. I did it. An' I'll tell you why, Warden. It was his eyes. He used to sit there starin' at me. The guards wouldn't put me in another cell. They just laughed, Warden. Thought it was funny, they did, him starin' at me like that. Five years, Warden, five years I stood it. Five years I stood those eyes. Then I killed him. That night when hell broke loose in the block an' everybody was fightin' back and forth in the corridor, I killed him. It was him or me, Warden, him or me -- So I squeezed

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his throat, 'till I knew he wouldn't stare at me no more. There, Warden, I confessed. Now hang me -- do anything to me -- only take me out of this hole. I'm afraid, Warden, I'm afraid of bein' alone in this dark -- I start seein' things -- I start seein' Mike's eyes again! *(shouts)*

Warden! Take me out! Open this door! Take me out! Take me out! Take me out! *(pause, silence, then almost timidly)* Warden!

Gone! He's gone! He's gone and left me here! In the dark. Pitch dark. Ssssh! What's that! Something movin'! Up there. Up there in the corner. Mike! No, no, it can't be Mike, or you could see his eyes. Take it easy now. The match. . . the one match you saved. Don't tremble! So, light it! *(strikes the match and then reacts)* A spider! It's a spider! He's weaving a web. He's weaving a web to catch flies! You fool, spider, you fool! There's no flies here. There's nothin' here except me. Me! Why don't you catch me in your web, spider? Why don't you catch me? I'll sit down and watch you. You're weaving, spider, back and forth, back and forth, back and forth. *(mesmerized)* Look, I can do that too. Back and forth, back and forth, back and forth, back and forth, back and forth, back and forth, the spider and I, back forth . . .

Stop it! Stop it, you hear Joe Ransom. You'll go nuts that way! Nuts, crazy, mad! Stop it!

What are you going to do? What are you going to do?

What was that? I heard something. I heard something drop. What was it? A button! A button came off my jacket. Here it is. Little button. White button. What do I want it for? What good can it do me? I'll throw it away. *(tosses the button)* Throw it away like I threw my life away.

Now it's gone. Gone like my life. Like everything. *(beat)* No, its not gone. It's still here. Here in this cell some place. I heard it. I heard it. I heard it drop. I threw it away like my life, like everything, but it's still here, here in the cell!

(determined) I've got to find it. I've got to find it, you hear? It means something! Now

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where is it? Where? I heard it hit the wall and then the floor. Is it under . . . *(looks under the cot)* Here it is! Here it is, the little button. I found it. It means something. I know. It's a game! I play the game and it keeps me from thinkin'. It makes me tired and then I can sleep. Sleep! And not see Mike's eyes. This is it! I'm saved! Saved! Play it again. Close your eyes.

Now throw! This side. It went over there. No! Further to the left. There it is. This is it! This'll save me! I was a sucker to shoot off my mouth to the Warden like that. Well, it wasn't in writing, that was one good thing! I'll have to get hold of a mouthpiece right away, there must be something . . . *(long beat)* Insanity! That's it. Pull the nut act! Boy, oh boy, oh boy, I'm saved!

The button! The button, you fool! Throw the button. Play that game! Throw! Over here. No. over further. That was near the other side. Near the door. No. Here? No. Where? Where? Oh, here it is! What would happen if I couldn't find it? What would happen in a little stone cell? Where could it get lost? Play! Throw the button!

That was near the bed. No nearer the middle – there! But if it did get lost? Stop it! It can't get lost! Play the game. Play and forget! Shut your eyes. Put your arm back and throw!

(he slowly descends into madness) Throw? I threw. I threw the button. I threw the button, but I didn't hear it hit. I threw and it didn't hit. I didn't hear it hit anything. All I can hear is my heart beating, beating, beating. Pounding -- pounding in my ears.

I threw the button and now it's gone. It didn't hit the walls, the floor, anything. I threw and it disappeared. It's gone! Gone! Where is it? What happened? I threw and it's, its gone! Something grabbed it! Something . . .

(terrified) Mike! Mike! Stop staring! Stop staring at me! Mike! Don't! Don't, Mike! Don't touch me, Mike!

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DR. TREVOR: *(on the phone)* Hello, hello. Yes, operator, get me the Warden's office. Hello, Warden? This is Dr.Trevor. *(beat)* Yes, I'm down in the solitary confinement wing. *(beat)* Yes. Yes, I examined him. *(beat)* No. I had him sent away. *(beat)* Yes. Completely, hopelessly mad. *(beat)* No, not a chance. His mind's gone. *(beat)* What caused it? Hard to say, sudden terrific shock or an emotional blow. Solitary confinement is a strain on the best of them. *(beat)* No, that's all. Oh, yes, one thing, very curious. I looked around the cell after he was taken away, there was a spider web in one corner. *(beat)* Yes, I said spider's web. And in the spider's web was a button - a little white button. Odd, isn't it.

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AWARD HISTORY

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